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Design Duel

After months of expectations, both Quark and Adobe, fortified with their latest versions, are fighting it out in the desktop publishing market. Guess who's winning?

Ever since Adobe InDesign was released, Adobe and QuarkXPress have been engaged in the battle of one-upmanship. Both QuarkXPress 5.0 and InDesign 2.0 continue in the same mould as their preceding versions and enhance usability for designers. Both of them, with almost similar features, are nearly indistinguishable except for the interface. The ability to create tables, Web pages with style sheets intact, and support for transparent effects on images (InDesign only) are some of the new features that have been introduced. However, there are two more important things both these upgrades are aiming at: making layout software as easy to use as a word processor, and increasing the emphasis on Web management.

Round 1: Tables

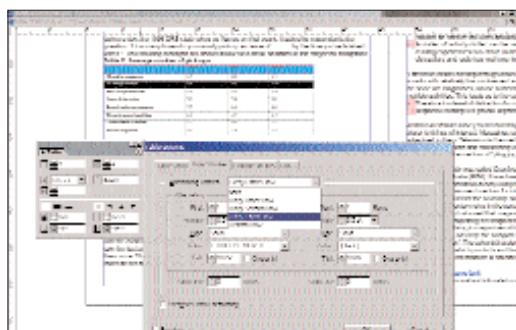
Any designer would tell you how much time is wasted in creating tables. Drawing grid lines and using tabbed text can be irritating at times and even a small

change in one row or column can change the text layout. But this is not so anymore in both Quark and InDesign. They come with inbuilt options for creating and importing tables.

InDesign offers more table options than Quark. You can split or merge cells and add diagonal lines, though you cannot fill text along the diagonal. InDesign seems to understand the designer's 'mentality' more, as one of the feature sets is

alternate shading or colouring of rows and columns (or every other two rows or columns). You have to select the row line or column line and format the same in Quark. Also, this software does not give border colour specifications at a cell level. The way the tables operate is different in both the software. In InDesign the row width expands to fill in the selection, while Quark overflows the text.

The superiority of InDesign is established once you try and import a table from an Excel spreadsheet or a Word table. It automatically recognises the cells in Word or Excel. Quark, on the other hand, doesn't import from Excel and tables in Word are imported as tab-delimited text which can be converted to tables using the Convert Text to Tables option. Even this doesn't recognise the formatting totally, as text doesn't wrap around cells automatically. The row-height has to be increased



The Tables feature in InDesign has a number of characteristics that make working simpler